

she was in a hurry; she was going with the editor's wife to the High Court to file a petition for the editor's release.

'God forbid,' said Daadi.

'You can't leave it to God,' said my mother.

'Don't say such things!'

'Can't leave it to anyone.'

'But why must you go?'

'I have to.'

Daadi went into the dressing room, returned with an amulet, hung it around my mother's neck and said that it would bring bad luck if she took it off before the period of uncertainty had ended.

Daadi had voted in the last election for the leader of what was then the opposition party. She went with Suri and Hukmi to the voting booths in the FC College grounds, dabbed her thumb in purple ink, pressed it on the voting slip, oversaw the insertion of the slip into the green box, and came home and held up the stain on her thumb.

She was pleased when her man won the election. She wore her large glasses and sat before the TV, and heard his address to the nation, in which he talked about the well-known corruption of the

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last government, and promised to make improvements, to build roads and give electricity and gas to the villages. He spoke in a halting, roving way, repeating phrases and saying the words in different pitches, until he had landed like an airborne thing on the end of his original point.

Daadi watched his round, fair face, his large, fair hands, and said with a mixture of surprise and admiration that he looked like a foreigner.

'The wife is even fairer,' said Suri, who had seen her in a shop.

'The whole family,' said Hukmi.

But there were stories about him, and they had led to accusations that were being considered in the Supreme Court.

Daadi said, 'The judges are making a mistake.'

The Supreme Court building was attacked. A clip from the storming was shown again and again on the news channels: a minister from the present government was leading the mob of agitators towards the big white building in Islamabad. The judges were hearing the case inside.

Daadi said, 'Judges? They are the most corrupt.'

The president of the country resigned and a new one was appointed.

Daadi said, 'It happens.'

My mother said the new prime minister was trying to become the king of the country.

Daadi said it was a misunderstanding that had happened between two people. 'It happens all the time,' she said. 'People come and people go. Not everything is like your politics.'

Then, at the start of the summer, it was reported that India had tested a nuclear missile. The footage was shown on the channels, the beige uniforms of the marching Indian soldiers and the slogans of the crowds that cheered for them in the streets.

Daadi said, 'They are coming.'

My mother said, 'There will be sanctions.'

But Daadi said, 'They will come. Allah help us. They will come for us now.'

Pakistan responded to India's nuclear tests by conducting its own: the footage of the trembling desert, where the tests were conducted, was accompanied by the sound of a distant rumbling. There was dancing in the streets of Lahore. Naseem came home at night from the market and said that the world was ablaze with lights, there were firecrackers and fireworks everywhere, she had heard the firing and seen the men with the Kalakshnikovs standing on rooftops.

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The government declared a state of emergency. A voice on Radio Pakistan announced in the morning that the right to convene any court, including a High Court or the Supreme Court, had been temporarily suspended.

My mother laughed and said, 'King of this country.'

He appeared on PTV, sitting at a desk with a portrait of the Founder of the Nation in its golden frame behind him on the wall, and said that the world was trying to punish Pakistan for declaring its independence. These were trying times, he said, but Pakistan had always emerged from its trials. He urged his fellow citizens, his brothers and his sisters, to stand with him in this time, to cut down on their daily spending and to pause and to think.

Hukmi said, 'Be a Pakistani and buy the Pakistani,' and it was a formal-sounding version of the slogan that was attached to the back of her car.

Suri said, 'If we don't, who will?'